

The First Meeting

Ren meets his new client — and her PM

Kurosawa Digital headquarters, 23rd floor. Ren adjusts his collar in the elevator reflection. His portfolio is on a tablet; his project plan is mostly in his head. The receptionist leads him to a glass-walled conference room where a woman in a crisp blazer is arranging printed documents in precise stacks.

Saki (咲希) "Welcome to Kurosawa Digital. I'm Sakurai Saki, the project manager assigned to the XR platform initiative. You must be from Pulse Works."

Ren (蓮) "That's me. Aoyama Ren. Thanks for having us — well, having me. The rest of the team sends their best."

Saki (咲希) "Let's begin. I've prepared an overview of the **project lifecycle** we'll follow — five phases, from initiation through closing. I trust you've brought your project charter?"

→ A *project lifecycle* is the series of phases a project passes through from start to finish. Saki is referencing the standard five phases: Initiating, Planning, Executing, Monitoring & Controlling, and Closing.

Ren (蓮) "Charter? I've got something better — a demo reel of our XR work. Clients usually love seeing what we can actually build."

Saki (咲希) "Impressive work. But a demo reel isn't a governance document. Before we discuss capabilities, I need to understand how you structure your **project phases**. How do you handle the transition from **initiating** to **planning**?"

→ *Project phases* are distinct stages with defined deliverables. The transition between phases — called a *phase gate* — is where teams formally decide whether to proceed. Saki is testing whether Ren follows a structured approach.

Ren (蓮) "Honestly? We usually jump from 'the client said yes' straight to building. We're a small studio — we move fast."

Saki (咲希) "Moving fast without a plan isn't speed. It's drift. At Kurosawa Digital, we don't begin **execution** until planning deliverables are formally approved."

→ The *execution phase* is where the project plan is put into action and deliverables are produced. Saki's point: skipping the planning phase doesn't save time — it creates uncontrolled risk.

Ren (蓮) "I hear you. But some of our best work came from figuring things out as we went. Structure can also slow you down."

Saki (咲希) "Then I suppose we'll need to find a balance. I look forward to seeing how Pulse Works operates under... governance."

Ren (蓮) "And I look forward to seeing if all those printed documents can keep up with us."

→ The tension between Ren's agile instincts and Saki's structured approach will be a recurring theme. Both perspectives have merit — effective PM often means knowing when to apply each.

Saki almost smiles. Almost. Ren notices.

Concept Discovery — Project Lifecycle & Phases

1 The Five Process Groups. When Saki mentioned the "five phases, from initiation through closing," she was referencing the PMBOK's five process groups: **Initiating** (defining the project and getting authorization), **Planning** (establishing scope, schedule, and cost), **Executing** (carrying out the plan), **Monitoring & Controlling** (tracking progress and managing changes), and **Closing** (formal completion and handoff). These aren't strictly sequential — monitoring happens throughout — but they provide the backbone of structured project management.

Tip Even small teams benefit from touching all five groups. You don't need heavy documentation — but you need conscious transitions.

2 Phase Gates: The Decision Points. Saki's question about "the transition from initiating to planning" points to **phase gates** — formal checkpoints where the team evaluates whether to proceed, pivot, or stop. Ren's studio skips these entirely ("the client said yes, so we start building"), which is common in small teams but risky on large engagements. A phase gate doesn't have to be a board meeting — even a 15-minute team check-in asking "do we have what we need to move forward?" counts.

Phoenix Project Connection In *The Phoenix Project*, the team learns that uncontrolled work-in-progress starts when projects enter execution without proper planning gates. Flow begins with discipline at the entry point.